Stress

Most people feel stressed sometimes and some people find stress helpful or even motivating. But if stress is affecting your life, there are things you can try that may help.

Support is also available if you're finding it hard to cope with stress.

Symptoms of stress

Stress can cause many different symptoms. It might affect how you feel physically and mentally, and also how you behave.

It's not always easy to recognise when stress is the reason you're feeling or acting differently.

Physical symptoms
Mental symptoms
Changes in behaviour

Things you can try to help with stress

Do

try talking about your feelings to a friend, family member or health professional – you could also contact Samaritans by phone on 116 123 if you need someone to talk to

find out more about 10 stress busters – including getting started with exercise and setting aside time for yourself

use easy time-management techniques to help you take control

use breathing exercises for stress

plan ahead for stressful days or events – planning long journeys or making a list of things to remember can really help

consider peer support, where people use their experiences to help each other – find out more about peer support on the Mind website

listen to free mental wellbeing audio guides

Don’t

do not try to do everything at once – set small targets you can easily achieve

do not focus on the things you cannot change – focus your time and energy on helping yourself feel better

try not to tell yourself that you're alone – most people feel stressed at some point in their life and support is available

try not to use alcohol, cigarettes, gambling or drugs to relieve stress – these can all contribute to poor mental health

Further information and support
Mind – managing stress and building resilience: get advice to help you adapt and bounce back during difficult times
Every Mind Matters – improve your mental health with our Mind Plan: personalised mental wellbeing tips and advice to your email inbox
Every Mind Matters – self-help cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT) techniques: learn how to manage stress and worry, and boost your mental wellbeing
Where to get NHS help for stress
Referring yourself for therapy
NHS talking therapies for anxiety and depression may be able to help with stress.

If you're 18 or over (or 16 or over in some areas), you can refer yourself directly without talking to a GP.

Find NHS talking therapies for anxiety and depression
If you're under 18, find out more about mental health support for children and young people.

See a GP if:
you're struggling to cope with stress
things you're trying yourself are not helping
you would prefer to get a referral from a GP
Call NHS 111 or ask for an urgent GP appointment if:
you need help urgently, but it's not an emergency
NHS 111 can tell you the right place to get help if you need to see someone. You can call 111 or get help from 111 online.

Call 999 or go to A&E now if:
you or someone you know needs immediate help
you have seriously harmed yourself – for example, by taking a drug overdose
A mental health emergency should be taken as seriously as a physical emergency.

Find your nearest A&E
Do not drive to A&E. Ask someone to drive you or call 999 and ask for an ambulance.

Bring any medicines you take with you.

Causes of stress
Stress is usually a reaction to mental or emotional pressure. It's often related to feeling like you're losing control over something, but sometimes there's no obvious cause.

When you're feeling anxious or scared, your body releases stress hormones such as adrenaline and cortisol.

This can be helpful for some people and stress might help you get things done or feel more motivated.

But it might also cause physical symptoms such as a faster heartbeat or sweating. If you're stressed all the time, it can become a problem.

Identifying the cause
If you know what's causing your stress, it might be easier to find ways to manage it.

Some examples of things that may cause stress include:

work – feeling pressure at work, unemployment or retirement
family – relationship difficulties, divorce or caring for someone
financial problems – unexpected bills or borrowing money
health – illness, injury, or losing someone (grief after bereavement or loss)
Even significant life events such as buying a house, having a baby or planning a wedding could lead to feelings of stress.

You might find it hard to explain to people why you feel this way, but talking to someone could help you find a solution.